全民英檢中級 GEPT Intermediate | 第 10 單元 | 購物與金錢 · Shopping & Money

How a Pair of Sneakers Taught Me to Budget

一雙球鞋教會我做預算

Every month my parents give me an allowance of two thousand dollars. It sounds like a fortune to a sixteen-year-old, yet until last spring I was broke by the twentieth of every month. The reason was simple: I had never kept a budget. Money went out as fast as it came in, mostly on bubble tea, phone games, and anything with a red discount tag.

The turning point was a pair of limited-edition sneakers. The price tag said 3,600 dollars, a sum I clearly could not afford. A sales clerk at the counter told me it was a bargain because the shoes would 'go up in value'. I had no money, so I borrowed 1,500 from my cousin, used the whole of my allowance, and walked to the checkout feeling like a wealthy investor. Two weeks later the sneakers were on sale for 2,400, and I owed my cousin money I did not have.

That was when my mother sat me down with a notebook. We wrote down every expense of the previous month, from the grocery store snacks to the bookstore manga. Then we made a plan: forty percent for daily spending, thirty percent for saving in my bank account, twenty percent to pay back my cousin, and ten percent to donate to the animal shelter near our school. I was told to keep every receipt and to wait three days before buying anything that cost more than five hundred dollars.

Six months later, my savings have grown to nine thousand dollars, my debt is gone, and I can finally tell a real bargain from a clever sales pitch. I still love sneakers. The difference is that now I buy them with money I actually have, and I no longer need to exchange my peace of mind for a pair of shoes.

重點單字 Key Vocabulary

單字	詞性	中文	例句
allowance	*n.*	零用錢	I get a weekly allowance of five hundred dollars. 我每週有五百元零用錢。
broke	*adj.*	沒錢的；破產的	I am broke until payday, so I cannot go out tonight. 發薪日前我都沒錢，所以今晚不能出去。

budget	*n.*	預算	Our family keeps a strict budget for food each month. 我們家每個月的伙食費有嚴格的預算。
tag	*n.*	標籤	The price on the tag was wrong, so I asked the clerk. 標籤上的價格錯了，所以我問了店員。
afford	*v.*	負擔得起	We cannot afford a trip abroad this year. 我們今年負擔不起出國旅行。
bargain	*n.*	划算的交易；便宜貨	This jacket was a real bargain at only three hundred dollars. 這件外套只要三百元，真是便宜。
checkout	*n.*	結帳櫃檯	There was a long line at the checkout. 結帳櫃檯排了長長的隊伍。
owe	*v.*	欠（錢、人情）	I owe my brother two hundred dollars for lunch. 午餐的錢我欠我哥哥兩百元。
expense	*n.*	開銷；費用	Rent is our biggest monthly expense. 房租是我們每個月最大的開銷。
receipt	*n.*	收據	Keep the receipt in case you want to return the shirt. 把收據留著，以防你想退這件襯衫。

片語 Phrases

go up in value	增值	Old comic books sometimes go up in value. 舊漫畫書有時候會增值。
pay back	還錢	I will pay you back next Monday. 我下週一還你錢。
tell A from B	分辨 A 與 B	Can you tell a real diamond from a fake one? 你能分辨真鑽和假鑽嗎？

文法與句型 Grammar

S + V, yet + S + V

yet 當連接詞時意思是「但是；然而」，語氣比 but 稍微正式，用來連接兩個意思相反的子句。

It sounds like a lot of money, yet I was always broke.

這聽起來是很多錢，但我總是沒錢。

S + be + told + to + V

「被告知要…；被要求…」。tell sb. to V 的被動語態，動作者常省略。

I was told to keep every receipt.

我被要求保留每一張收據。

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